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Dangerous bodies, a corrupted tongue: tracing the queer Persianate in late Ottoman literature

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ABSTRACT
For authors of the early twentieth century Millî Edebiyat [National Literature] movement like Ömer Seyfettin (1884-1920) and Halide Edip Adıvar (1884-1964), the notion of a pernicious Ottoman 'Persophilia' served as a crucial negative ground against which a new Turkish literary modernity could be defined. In their writings before the outbreak of the First World War, these two authors established a direct link between the construction of a 'healthy' language purged from Persianate influence, and the inculcation of a vital, productive, and patriotic heteronormativity. The influence of Persophilia was typified by two abject figures: the court poet entranced by the *hat-âver*, *çar-ebru* [thinly-moustached, four-browed] young male beloved, and the Persianate woman, oppressed by the customs of *pederşahilik* [father-kingship]. This article traces the genealogy of these two motifs in Ottoman discourse, to explore why these particular figures became so problematised, constituted as a locus of gendered and sexual anxiety, and ultimately deemed so threatening by these authors as to demand a total break with the heritage of the Ottoman past. It concludes by discussing the political possibilities of the queered Persianate, and how motifs like the *şahmeran* [serpent-queen] have been deployed as a symbol of queer and minoritarian resistance in contemporary Turkey.

KEYWORDS
Turkish literature; Persianate; queer theory; heteronormativity; Ottoman feminism

Introduction: the queer Persianate

'But let us abandon that ornate language, fit only for the subjects of pleasure and desire, sycophancy and hypocrisy; the old language, the language of yesterday, which was born of a five-century-old irrationality and queerness' (Ömer Seyfettin 1911, 6).[1] So wrote the short story author, poet, and soldier Ömer Seyfettin (1884–1920) towards the end of the literary manifesto 'Yeni Lisan' ['New Language'], published in the April 11, 1911 issue of the Thessaloniki-based journal *Genç Kalemler* [*The Young Pens*].[2] The consequences were to be as revolutionary as Ömer Seyfettin had hoped. 'There was a literary language before Ömer Seyfettin', writes the historian Zafer Toprak, 'and another literary language

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[1]'Yeni Lisan' was first published in three parts under the pseudonym '?', with the first section written by Ömer Seyfettin, the second by Ali Canip [Yöntem], and the third by Ziya Gökalp. All citations below will refer to Ömer Seyfettin's portion.
[2]For an overview of this movement, see Öksüz 2016.

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after' (2020, 340). Ömer Seyfettin's emphasis was not so much technical as rhetorical: he offered a damning analysis of the various 'sicknesses' of Ottoman Turkish literature, its 'hereditary disease', and 'paralysis'. These pathologies had their root, he argued, in the ancient Persianate custom of gender segregation, which had prevented the expression of 'love and lovemaking' that would have constituted a healthy and productive literature. Prohibited from 'that wonderful, pleasurable, disaffirming whirlpool into which all peoples that have made progress have fallen into', Turkish literature had thus over the centuries 'morphed into an extremely artificial state, and one contrary to nature' (1911, 2). After centuries of perverse imitation, to restore Turkish to its former purity and naturalness would require purging the language of its useless and extraneous 'ornamentation', and realigning written language to the spoken form of an idealised, uncontaminated, and vital Istanbul Turkish. At once, then, a new literature, a new language, and – in the words of the widely-influential Turkish nationalist ideologue Ziya Gökalp (1876–1924) – a 'new life' [*yeni hayat*] (1918).

In the summer of the following year, the novelist, journalist, and political activist Halide Edip [Adıvar] (1884–1964) completed her own strident manifesto, the serial novel *Yeni Turan* [*New Turan*] (2014). Ziya Gökalp was a shared interlocutor between Halide Edip and Ömer Seyfettin, and all three shared an interest in the notion of radical break with the past. Indeed, Ömer Seyfettin would later praise *Yeni Turan* as 'the Gospel of Turkish nationalism', and it remains recognised as among the earliest, and perhaps the most enduring, examples of speculative political fiction in Turkish literature (1919a, 11). The events of the novel take place in an imagined 1930s, in which the Ottoman Empire has become ideologically divided by two rival parties: the Yeni Turan, who aim to transform the state into a pan-Turkic federation called Turan, and the reactionary and corrupt Yeni Osmanlı [New Ottoman] party. Like their leader, the young politician Oğuz, members of the Yeni Turan wear simple, modest clothes and take new names which hearken back to pre-Islamic Turkic culture.[3] Above all, they emphasise an absolute gender equality. The novel's heroine, the Yeni Turan activist Kaya [lit. 'rock'], is depicted as an austere, haunting, androgynous figure. As Halide Edip writes, 'there was absolutely nothing male or female in her gaze, or anything that reminded people of gender' (Adıvar 2014, 32). To save Oğuz from imminent execution, Kaya reluctantly agrees to abandon politics and marry Hamdi Pasha, the aged leader of the Yeni Osmanlı. Hamdi Pasha, who has desired Kaya since she was a young girl, attempts to restore her femininity by dressing her in bright colours and diamonds, and emplacing her 'like an antique' within the fashionable furniture of his Istanbul mansion (63, 68). Kaya does not openly resist Hamdi Pasha, but her inability to actively enjoy her objectification is diagnosed as severe neurasthenia and she is gradually drugged into compliance. Four years into Kaya's marriage, Oğuz is killed by an assassin inspired by the Yeni Osmanlı's misogynist rhetoric. Despite Hamdi Pasha's best efforts and increasingly desperate pleas, Kaya learns of his death, recovers her former vitality, and escapes from her marriage. Although the plot and tone of the novel is reminiscent of Halide Edip's other melancholic romances, like the contemporaneous *Handan* (1912), its extensive, didactic ideological content – largely in the form of Oğuz's speeches –

[3]The term Oğuz, referring to an ancestral branch of the Turks, was also used as a patriotic name by Ömer Seyfettin in the explicitly Turanist novella 'Primo Türk Çocuğu' (1911-1914).

represents a turning point in her oeuvre and within Turkish literature at large. It is for this reason that the translator and scholar Erdağ Göknar considers *Yeni Turan* to be both a 'transitional text' and paradigmatic of the political and literary debates of its time (2009, 481–482).

Ömer Seyfettin and Halide Edip are commonly read together as the leading writers of the *Millî Edebiyat* [National Literature] era, a period of extraordinary violence and literary disruption usually bounded on one end by the publication of 'Yeni Lisan' in 1911, and on the other by the declaration of the Turkish Republic in 1923.[4] Certainly, it is true that both Ömer Seyfettin and Halide Edip shared intellectual circles, commented on each other's works, and wrote upon similar problems: above all, thinking through what a specifically Turkish literature should consist of, and which linguistic, aesthetic, political, social, and sexual norms this literature should serve to inculcate. The writings of both continue to form core components of the national primary, middle, and high school curricula (Ogur 2020).[5] At the same time, however, I would argue that the uncritical use of this designation obscures their significant personal and intellectual differences. Aside from 'Yeni Lisan', Ömer Seyfettin is best known for the prolific short stories he wrote in 'new language': in addition to being hailed by Gökalp as 'the Christopher Columbus of our literary Turkish' (Levend 1949, 382) he has also been regarded as 'our Maupassant' (Yöntem 2005, 398) or else 'Turkey's Anton Chekhov' (Karpat 2009, 199). For my part, I follow critics of the period like Edward G. Browne in placing him more comfortably alongside figures like Filippo Tommaso Marinetti and Gabriele d'Annunzio (Browne 1914: xxxix): like Marinetti, there is the valorisation of youth, speed, stripped-down speech, and spilled blood; like D'Annunzio, Ömer Seyfettin's writing evinces a fin-de-siecle fascination with lurid depictions of gendered violence, torture, mutilation, and death. As Serkan Özdemir notes, the influence of Sade upon Ömer Seyfettin's politics and eroticism was profound, and explicit depictions of sadomasochism run throughout both his war stories and his domestic dramas; it is an influence which perhaps could have made his writing politically transgressive but which – with a few exceptions – has been largely put to the service of a deeply reactionary project (Özdemir 2020, 263). Perhaps surprisingly, Ömer Seyfettin's sadism has largely been downplayed by scholars including those, like Nergis Ertürk, who are deeply critical of his politics (2011).[6] It has only been the historian and critic Halil Berktay who has proposed that Seyfettin's proto-fascistic nationalism and linguistic purism may be rooted in a fundamentally erotic source (2010, 109).[7]

If Ömer Seyfettin represents the more reactionary side of the National Literature movement, Halide Edip is generally taken to represent its liberal wing: an emancipatory civic nationalism which 'prefigures the later interventions of post-colonial feminism' (Göknar 2013, 53). Whereas Ömer Seyfettin's citations are almost wholly continental, Halide Edip's writing and thought evinces an almost affected Anglophilia; an affiliation

[4]For a general overview of this period see Enginün 2006; Arai 1992.

[5]Although there have been efforts to remove his more violent stories, Ömer Seyfettin is still taught at all levels. Halide Edip's works are taught in middle or high school.

[6]Ertürk's Derridean reading strangely concurs with Turkish nationalist historiography in de-eroticizing Ömer Seyfettin and regarding the sadism and violence in his work as simple depictions of the crimes of the Other. Yet such scenes also occur in his domestic stories, and as Murat Belge notes, Ömer Seyfettin inserts himself and his own views into his sadistic characters regardless of their national identity (2009, 101).

[7]Selim İleri made a similar argument in the 1970s, although he later repudiated this stance (1975).

which would later support the characterisation of her as a *mandacı* [League of Nations mandate-supporter] and national traitor following her political split with Mustafa Kemal Atatürk in 1925 (Adak 2003; Durakbaşa 2000). Outside of Turkey, however, the image of Halide Edip in academic literature has long been that of the exemplary nationalist feminist author and activist, whose personal culpability in the crimes of that nationalism has been seen as a tragic aberration (Jayawardena 1986, 40–41).[8] This idealised depiction of Halide Edip, based on her later English-language works, rather deemphasises the more formative period of her politics vis-à-vis Ottoman feminism, as well as her evolving conceptualisation of the relationship between gender, desire, and nationalist ideology. Scholars have noted how earlier novels like *Yeni Turan* tend to juxtapose an ungendered, politicised love for the national collective against the selfishness and debasement of possessive, individual desire; indeed, the main psychic difference between Kaya and the eponymous heroine of *Handan*, who is described in similarly androgynous terms, is that Kaya's love is framed through the political and Handan's is not (Argunsah 2015; Gözdaşoğlu Küçükalioğlu 2007; Saraçgil 2005, 193). This 'asexuality' has generally been read as a compromise, in which women give up their sexual desire in exchange for participation in the nationalist project (Kandiyoti 1988, 45–46; Sancar 2012, 142). As Hülya Adak has noted, however, this distinction applies to male-gendered characters as well, and in the context of the Kemalism's later pronatalist and maternalist politics Halide Edip's idealisation of 'the chaste daughter of the Republic' in novels like 1922's *Ateşten Gömlek* [*The Shirt of Fire*] and 1923's *Vurun Kahpeye* [*Beat the Slut*] can be read as subverting, even as these works in large part served to construct, the role of the 'comrade-woman' within Turkish nationalism (Adak 2004, 166–168).

We have, then, an essay and a novel; a proto-fascistic politics and a liberal feminist one; a writer who is fascinated largely by ecstatic sadistic pleasure and another by chaste, self-sacrificing love. What they both share, together with Ziya Gökalp and the other writers of the National Literature movement, is a valorisation of the radical break: the 'new' that constitutes the rupture of both 'Yeni Lisan' and *Yeni Turan*. But a rupture with *what*, exactly? What was so threatening to both authors, so contaminating, as to demand a total rupture in language, literature, and society? To say, 'the past', or perhaps 'the Ottoman past', seems to me both too broad and too simple: it would equally apply to both Ömer Seyfettin and Halide Edip's ideological opponents (such as the Edebiyat-ı Cedide [New Literature] and the Fecr-i Âti [Coming Dawn] literary movements), as well as presuppose a not yet evident irreconcilability between the political aims of Turkism and the Ottoman state. Rather, what I want to argue in this article is that – in so far as the rupture each author proposed took place within the interlinkage of gender difference, normative desire, and literary language – it is above all against a shared notion of *Iran* or *the Persianate* that Ömer Seyfettin and Halide Edip constructed their visions of utopian futurity. Further, I would add that inasmuch as the National Literature writers envisaged this 'new life' as socially constituted and reproduced by a new order of productive desire between men and women, the Persianate thus became retroactively configured as queered negative of a future heteronormative sexuality. What the Turkish intellectuals of the period termed *Acemperestlik*, or Persophilia, was likewise imagined as a primeval corrupting disease within Turkish culture, given symptomatic

[8]For her role in the operation of residential schools during the Armenian Genocide, see Adak 2016; Deringil 2019.

expression by abject figures in need of radical rejection, excision, and estrangement.[9] To be sure, this dynamic may seem more accurately characterised by *phobia* rather than *philia*, but in using the term Persophilia here I am both attempting to remain closer to the sense of *Acemperestlik,* as well as to indicate a broader literary-historical discourse rather than just its rhetorical tone. I will place this Persophilia in connection with Hamid Dabashi's formulation of this term later in this article (2015). For now, it is important to emphasise that while this Persophilia constituted a self-referential and coherent discourse, its rhetorical emphases were varied, evolving, and strategic: for instance, the primary instantiation of the Persianate abject differed significantly between Ömer Seyfettin and Halide Edip.

Ömer Seyfettin opens his discussion of Persophilia in 'Yeni Lisan' by contrasting the eroticism of the Arabs with the 'civilised' Ottoman Turks. 'Because of their Bedouin character', he writes, 'the Arabs were able to love women, and were able to create truly effective and passionate poetry' (1911, 2). By contrast, under the influence of the Persianate gender segregation, Ottoman poets abandoned 'plain and simple reality' in favour of the 'ever-changing, multi-coloured, empty artificiality of the imagination'. Because they were 'unable to make true love, poets started to fall in love with their fantasies'. He points to several eighteenth and nineteenth-century literary works as exemplary of this unnatural, fantastical Persophilia within Ottoman Turkish: namely, Nedim's *Hammamiyye* (c. 1720s), Enderunlu Fazıl Bey's *Hubannâme* (c. 1790s), Sünbülzade Vehbi's *Tuhfe* and *Şevkengiz* (c. 1790s), Osman Rahmi Bey's *Nâme-i Dil* (1861), and Muallim Naci's *Heder* (1909).[10] Although this negative canon has generally been read as simply standing in for the broader corpus of Ottoman court literature [*divan edebiyâtı*], it seems to me to be a strikingly idiosyncratic list. Of these writers, only Nedim would commonly be considered among the greatest masters of *divan* poetry; only Vehbi could reasonably be considered a 'Persophile' on the basis of his literary works. *Heder* is perhaps the strangest addition, being neither poetry nor prose but a European-style staged drama. Instead, Ömer Seyfettin makes clear that it is a *certain perverse mode of erotic enjoyment* and its 'repulsive implications' that tie these works together. This enjoyment is typified by the fantasy of the youthful beloved: a figure whom Ömer Seyfettin, using conspicuously Persianate phrases 'which today's readers likely do not even know the meanings of', identifies as the '*hat-âver, çar-ebru*' [from Persian, 'thinly-moustached, four-browed'].[11] Although it is possible to read his argument here simply as an (anachronistic) condemnation of male homoeroticism or pederasty within Ottoman literature, it seems to me that – when read in the context of the broader discourse of Persophilia, as well as Ömer Seyfettin's own prescribed heteronormative sadomasochistic eroticism – what is truly condemned here are, to use Lee Edelman's terms, those 'sterile, narcissistic enjoyments' that are 'responsible for the undoing of social organization, collective reality, and, inevitably, life itself' (2004, 12–13). Ömer Seyfettin sets up the *divan* poet as an abject figure who has succumbed to the fantasy of the *çar-ebru* over procreative futurity and symbolic intelligibility. We might understand

[9]The term *Acemperestlik* is first used extensively by the literary historian Mehmet Fuat Köprülü, largely in the same manner of E.J.W. Gibb's earlier 'Persianism' (2007 [1921]: 58).

[10]There are errors in Ömer Seyfettin's list: he refers Nedim's ode as a 'Hamamnâme', and pluralises Muallim Naci's title as 'Hederler'. Vehbi's *Tuhfe*, a Perso-Ottoman verse dictionary, is not directly listed but referred to elsewhere in 'Yeni Lisan'.

[11]Both of these terms are found together in Vehbi's *Şevkengiz* (Schmidt 1993).

Ömer Seyfettin's need for radical rupture, then, in this way: as Julia Kristeva writes, the symptom of abjection is above all 'the rejection and reconstruction of languages' (1982, 45).

Halide Edip's writings, I argue, work through a similar problematic, but through the theorisation of a different abject figure. The notion of Turan, of course, originates within the Persianate mytho-historical tradition as the imperial counterpart of Iran; Ferdowsi's *Shahnameh* [*The Book of Kings*] is in large part a romance of these two sibling empires and, as Hamid Dabashi notes, a dialectical account in which 'Ferdowsi narrates the Iranian and Turanian victories and defeats in equal measure passionately and convincingly' (2019, 140–141). Building upon an earlier association between Turan and the Turkic-speaking peoples of Central Asia, philologists of the nineteenth century like Max Müller proposed the Turanian as a 'middle' racial and linguistic category alongside the Aryan and the Semite, encompassing the Ottoman and Central Asian Turks, as well as the Hungarians and Finns (1854). In so far as Turkism adopted this racial and geographic imaginary whilst (formally) abandoning Ferdowsi's dialectics, Iran appeared in their writings as an alien obstacle lodged within a broader Turanian expanse: see Ömer Seyfettin's description of 'spoilt Iran placed right in the centre of brave Turan' (1917), for example, or Halide Edip's mention in *Yeni Turan* of a 'wretched Iran' inviting conquest by a revitalised Ottoman Empire (Adıvar 2014, 44). Yet Iran also represented an obstacle on a more fundamental level. Like Ömer Seyfettin, Halide Edip viewed the influence of Iran upon the ancient Turks to be a cultural catastrophe: whereas the 'warlike, just and open character' of the Arabs would have constituted a natural and productive literature, the idolisation of 'cypress-bodied, snake-haired, purse-lipped Persianate beauty' instead sunk the Ottomans into useless and artificial fantasy (1913; 2004, 183). Above all, Persophilia's 'unnatural tendencies expelled women from literature' (1913); under the sway of 'Persian thought, Persian perspectives, and Persian philosophy', women were 'crushed and despised for centuries', unseen and unrepresented, ultimately becoming nothing more than 'meat and machinery' excluded even from the realm of erotic desire (1909). Together with Ziya Gökalp, Halide Edip theorised that the primeval Turks had, by contrast, been essentially 'democratic and feminist': among them existed no political distinctions of class or gender, until the influence of Iran had instilled within them the twin poisons of tyranny and gender difference (Gökalp 2019, 151, 160–162). A similar fate, Gökalp claimed, had befallen the Arabs during the Abbasid period (Saraçgil 2005, 175). To describe this influence, Gökalp would coin a new, distinctly Persianate calque from the French *patriarchie*: *peder-şahi-lik* ['father-kingship'],[12] in which women and children are the chattel of the husband/father. I read the androgyny of Kaya in this light: her re-entry into the realm of the political and is correlated with her return to an ancestral, vital, Turkic ungendered self, whereas the Yeni Osmanlı's attempts to

[12]Ziya Gökalp's writings are the earliest recorded source of this word, which has since been replaced by the modern Turkish *ataerkil*. To be clear, I am not arguing that this neologism is, by virtue of its etymology, essentially 'Persianate'. However, although he was opposed to strict literary purism [*dilde tasfiyecilik*] Ziya Gökalp *did* clearly argue that Arabic and Persian words remained essentially foreign to Turkish except when consecrated by popular usage. His calque of *pedarşahilik* from *patriarchie* is thus notable, especially in light of how the terms used to describe the ancestral Turkish family (i.e., *demokrat* and *feminist*) were left in direct translation (2019, 160).

force her back into an ornamental, sterile, useless femininity represents the despotic revanchism of Persianate *pederşahilik*.

Two Persianate abjects, then: the *divan* poet, succumbed to the fantasy of the *çar-ebru*, and the crushed woman, succumbed to the tyranny of *pederşahilik*. Set against this negative ground is vital, culturally productive desire, and a healthy, emancipatory symbolic order: a new language, a new Turan, and a new life. This, in short, constitutes the general argument of this article. In what follows, I aim to trace a tentative genealogy of these two abject figures within Ottoman literature up until the National Literature movement. Following this, I will return to the 'snake-haired' Persianate beauty condemned by Halide Edip, and briefly conclude by discussing the retroactive, strategic usage of the *şahmeran* [from Persian, lit. 'king of serpents' although usually gendered as feminine] motif as a locus of symbolic resistance to intensifying homophobic and transphobic violence in contemporary Turkey. As may be clear, this political notion of the queer Persianate is, on a conceptual level, at odds with my own usage here. As Joseph Massad has written, 'attempts to disseminate [queerness] as a social formation, or as a form of resistance, or as a desired form of social hegemony undercut its very ontological structure and its specific and very recent histories'; to universalise queerness transculturally and transhistorically as a specific set of self-evidently 'queer' social practices and modes of identification is thus to rob the term of any critical value and to constitute queerness as an essentially assimilatory and homogenising project (2015, 256). Consequently, I do not use this term here as a generic category for nonnormative or antinormative identities and modes of desire *within* sexual discourse, but rather to refer to that which is estranged and made incomprehensible *by* sexual discourse – those 'repulsive implications' which Ömer Seyfettin wrote 'today's readers likely do not even know the meanings of (Ömer Seyfettin 1911, 2)'. What defines the Persianate within Turkish heteronormativity as 'queer' in what follows is thus not any particular mode of desire or social identification, but rather its fundamental structural negativity: its retroactively projected role as the negative realm against which both Ömer Seyfettin and Halide Edip defined their projects of sexual futurity (Edelman 2004, 4). This negativity does not present us, as such, with a positive or utopian political project. Yet as Evren Savcı writes, 'the semantic dimension of language requires that we acknowledge that oftentimes what is produced is a complex, disjunctive, and heterogeneous field of meaning' (2021, 147). To insist that negativity cannot constitute the ground for collective action is, itself, a debatable notion (Berlant and Edelman 2014, 67), and I do not wish here to reproduce the dynamic noted by José Esteban Muñoz and Mari Ruti: that is, in which critics whose lives are not on the line, so to speak, valorise negativity, whilst those who are legitimately facing imminent destruction (social, political, and embodied) stress instead the importance of a positive politics (Muñoz 2009, 95–96; Ruti 2017, 124–129). Ultimately, it may be that it is precisely its ability to sustain such contradictions that makes the queer Persianate appear today, for better or for worse, as viable medium for broader resistance and critique.

Dangerous bodies, a corrupted tongue

'Those who want to learn Persian', wrote the famed author, journalist, and Young Ottoman intellectual Namık Kemal (1840–1888), 'should learn it after they have

grown a beard and moustache' (Tansel 1973, 115). The implication seems clear. But what is interesting, to me, are the dual meanings one may derive from it. On one hand, there is the knowledge of Persian as a long-eroticised feature of young men within Ottoman literary culture (Andrews and Kalpaklı 2005, 92, 135-136, 233). On the other hand, however, there is a sense of Persian as *itself* a mode of eroticism, a reading made more evident by Namık Kemal's earlier remarks. 'This blessed language', he writes, 'must no longer be seen at the gate of the school, alongside its incipient moustaches, its kisses and lovers, and its boy beloveds! (Tansel 1973, 115)' One may read similarly in the writings of Namık Kemal's contemporary, the extraordinarily prolific Ahmet Mithat Efendi (1844–1912). In his 1875 novel *Felatun Bey ile Rakım Efendi*, for example, Ahmet Mithat's author surrogate Rakım Efendi carelessly introduces Persian to two young English girls that he tutors: the effect is to violently awaken their 'amorous feelings' and 'completely intoxicate' them, to the point that one of the girls quickly succumbs to hysteria (2017 [1875]: 84). Rakım Efendi soon realises that it was Hafez's *Divan* that had 'brought her to this state,' and that she had been 'poisoning herself' by reading it (172). Such imagery persists into the National Literature period: in Halide Edip's 1910 novel *Seviyye Talip*, for instance, the Westernised Ottoman intellectual Fahir is so affected when the novel's eponymous heroine recites Omar Khayyam that he begins 'shivering like a sick child', falls into feverish neurosis, and eventually reverts to the state of a 'helpless and docile child' (Adıvar 1987, 80). In 'Yeni Lisan', Ömer Seyfettin will likewise write that 'those who think that these [*divan*] poet's praises, their "oohs" and "ahhs" and odes and tears were for women, must be as innocent as a just-circumcised child' (1911, 2).

This evident dichotomy between Persian, on one hand, and the childish innocence on the other, is interesting in light of how, as Nazan Maksudyan has described, it was precisely during this period that the notion of the 'vulnerable child' in need of state protection entered into Ottoman social discourse (2014, 84). Indeed, it would be the Young Ottoman reformist bureaucrat Mithat Pasha (1822–1883), Ahmet Mithat Efendi's patron and namesake, who would be the foremost proponent of the need to 'save' vulnerable children and discipline those who had fallen into delinquency and prostitution. We might say, then, that the discourse of Persophilia was, from the start, framed in terms of the defence of the Child; when Ömer Seyfettin analogises the purification of Turkish from Persian to the removal of women's corsets, 'thereby ensuring the next generation of children that they give birth to shall be a healthy one' (1911, 4) it is clear that he is building upon an already established rhetoric. Yet this opposition was only part of a larger dynamic, in which the Persianate was placed in direct opposition to life, futurity, and the social order. Within the discourse of Persophilia, the Persianate was attributed the lurid characteristics of fantasy, delirium, decay, and nihilistic, suicidal enjoyment. Persian literature appeared to these authors as a potent but deadly drug: a poisonous aphrodisiac like belladonna or Spanish fly. As Namık Kemal wrote in the famed introduction to his 1874 *Bahar-ı Daniş* [*Spring of Knowledge*], 'in truth, Persian literature is one of the most corrupted in world' (Göçgün 1987, 237). This, to me, is a remarkable statement from an Ottoman intellectual, but it is one that has aroused surprisingly little curiosity within the broader scholarship.

In recent decades, the study of late Ottoman literature and aesthetics has come to complicate a previously dominant analytic of cultural Westernisation – whether by

deconstructing the term itself (Ahıska 2003; Crofoot 1990; Hamadeh 2007), or by showing how Ottoman formal experimentation was not limited to the imitation of Western models or bound to a Western telos (Gürbilek 2003; Moran 1983; Parla 2004). This scholarship has offered a nuanced perspective far subtler than the stark dichotomy of East and West that had characterised earlier historiography; as we have seen, even within the supposed 'East', Arabic and Persian were assigned rather different values, and it was not until the Republic that Arabic overtook Persian as the primary target of reform. On a more conceptual level, however, it remains the case that the history of nineteenth and twentieth-century Turkish literature has largely been framed through the problematic of veracity, mimesis, and of proper fidelity to social life. As such, with few exceptions (Holbrook 2002; Katiboğlu 2020) it has tended to take for granted the other side of the equation: the notion of an aesthetic movement away from the 'fantastical', 'imaginary' or 'artificial' character of the Persianate. The terms habitually used throughout the discourse of Persophilia – 'Persianate exaggeration' [*mübalağa-ı Acemâne*] and 'Persianate fantasy' [*hayâlât-ı Acemâne*], for instance – have generally been taken as neutral, descriptive terms or idiomatic expressions rather than as, in this case, ideological statements. As Victoria Rowe Holbrook has noted, in so far as modern Turkish literary history is rooted in the thought of Young Ottoman authors like Namık Kemal, Abdülhak Hamit [Tarhan] (1852–1937), Recaizâde Mahmud Ekrem (1847–1914), and Abdülhalîm Memdûh (1866–1905), it 'monumentalised a local moment of anti-*divan* polemic' into the foundations of an entire field (1994, 27). Indeed, through the vehicle of Scottish orientalist E.J.W. Gibb's six-volume *A History of Ottoman Poetry* – in large part based on the critical opinions of Namık Kemal and Abdülhak Hamit, and then repeatedly retranslated back into Turkish by, among others, Halide Edip – this Persophilia was given the imprimatur of objective, Western criticism (Gibb 1900–1907; Gibb 1943; Holbrook 1994: 18–27; Yashin 2017). The entirety of Ottoman history could now be understood as a continuous struggle to break free from the 'Persian yoke' – the 'huge mass of useless accretions and false embellishments' from Iran – and to rescue Turkish from an 'effete and colourless Persianism' (Gibb 1900, 26–27). The citation of Gibb by both official literary histories (Köprülü 1921; Sevük 1924) as well as the more critical histories of Ahmet Hamdi Tanpınar and Güzin Dino (Dino 1951; Tanpınar 1988 [1949]) thus made it appear as if the claims of Persophilia were simply undisputed fact, a foundational premise which continues largely unexamined within general scholarship. Contemporary Turkish-language feminist and queer criticism has, by contrast, tended to focus less on the question of Westernisation and more on the internal ideological functions of late Ottoman Turkish literature as a specific sociopolitical project by a particular class formation. Jale Parla, Nurdan Gürbilek, and Serkan Delice have all emphasised, in different ways, how authors of the late Tanzimat period (1839–1876) attempted to reassert paternalist authority within the realm of literature even as such authority was rapidly being destabilised by the epistemological challenge of new scientific disciplines, increases in women's literacy, and changing erotic norms (Delice 2012; Gürbilek 2004; Parla 1990). In attempting to understand the ideological function of the queer Persianate, I borrow from the insights of all three scholars. The discourse of Persophilia, I argue, was deeply interconnected

with each of these readings in so far as it was posed not merely as a question of literary style or aesthetic taste but as an *existential* problem, a biopolitical counterpart to the epistemological crisis afflicting paternalist authority.

As the historian Gülhan Balsoy has noted, the Tanzimat period was marked not only by sociopolitical reforms but by a pronounced and broad-scaled pronatalist programme, rooted in fears of the imminent extinction of the Empire's Muslim population (2013, 3). It is no accident that the humanity-destroying plague of Mary Shelley's *The Last Man* (1998 [1826]) begins in Istanbul, for European discourse had long emphasised the relative depopulation and desolation of the Ottoman Empire (Varlık 2017). Such a problem was particularly acute in nineteenth-century Istanbul, where – as Alan Duben and Cem Bahar have shown – fertility rates among Muslims were extraordinarily low for a pre-industrial context, and both birth control and abortion were widely practiced (1991, 3–5, 159–193). As early as 1838, the Ottoman state launched an intensive propaganda and regulatory campaign against abortion and unlicensed midwifery on explicitly demographic terms, citing the need to increase the population vis-à-vis both foreign powers and the Empire's non-Muslim population (Balsoy 2013, 56–58). A key element of this strategy was the criticism of non-procreative desire as mere *tenperverlik* [lit. 'body-worship', with the implications of narcissistic debauchery or self-indulgence]. It is interesting to note, in this context, that it was precisely on this account (rather than for 'homoeroticism') that two of the works mentioned in Ömer Seyfettin's Persianate canon – Fazıl Bey's *Hubannâme* and Vehbi's *Şevkengiz* – were among the first works suppressed by an increasingly pronatalist state.[13] By the 1860s, it was clear that government policy had largely failed to solve the population issue, and the pronatalist rhetoric of Young Ottoman intellectuals turned increasingly vitriolic: Namık Kemal, for instance, compared women who practiced abortion to vermin, or else to animals addicted to selfish and narcissistic pleasure in the face of imminent extinction (see also Balsoy 2013, 71–72; Namık Kemal 1872a; 1872b). We can already see a certain convergence of thought with Persophilic discourse: on one side, there is perversity, fatal enjoyment, a turn away from life; on the other, the Child, productive desire, and the future of the Ottoman state. What linked these two discourses together over the course of the 1870s, I argue, were the ethnological expeditions sent from Istanbul to Central Asia during this period, which sought in the Turkmen of that region both the ancestors of the Ottoman Turks, and the secret to their renewed vitality.

The scholars Christoph Herzog and Raoul Motika have noted the strange sparsity of Ottoman travelogues to Iran during the late nineteenth century, proposing that perhaps it was as a competitor state that Iran was 'placed right at the bottom' of the Ottoman civilizational hierarchy and thus deemed unworthy of interest (2000, 141, 195). Here, I would propose a more fundamental reason. Explorations of Persophilia were conducted primarily through a constant and repetitive analysis, excavation, and excision of the Ottoman self; it was essentially negative, and thus did not necessarily see the need to

[13]During this period these two works, along with the other erotic writings of Enderunlu Fazıl Bey, were usually found bound together in one compilation. In 1837 the print version of this compilation was censored on the grounds that it mocked marriage and encouraged debauchery, but it is unclear which work in particular may have provoked state intervention. See Kuru 2005.

travel to Iran to confirm its claims.[14] Indeed, in so far as possible, it placed Iran itself under a *cordon sanitaire* and sought to understand only the symptomatic effects of its influence. Perhaps the most paradigmatic example is Mehmet Emin Efendi's (1854–1925) 1877 travelogue *İstanbul'dan Asya-yı Vusta'ya Seyahat* [*Journey from Istanbul to Central Asia*], which was serialised in Ahmet Mithat Efendi's newspaper *Tercüman-ı Hakikat* [*Translator of Truth*] and published with a foreword by him, and which sought to understand how 'the Turkmens, our fathers and brothers' had 'completely preserved their ancient aspects' (2007, 11). Although inspired in large part by the earlier travelogue of the Hungarian Turcologist Ármin Vámbéry (1832–1913), Mehmet Emin's account differed in its attempt to locate, within Istanbulite Ottoman customs, those which were originally Turkish and vital and those which had succumbed to corruption from Iran (Vámbéry 1864; 1878). Among the Turkmens, Mehmed Emin found a society in which 'the women are not idle, veiled and savage [*miskin, mestûr, vahşi*] like ours here, but quite free' (65). By contrast, he writes, 'in Iran, not even the tips of women's fingers are visible. Even before Islam, such was the case in Iran'. Unlike among the Ottomans, where even 'an eighteen or twenty-year-old young man refuses to go out into the street without a nanny by his side' the Turkmen raise 'lion children, both lion girls and lion boys (Mehmet Emin 2007, 66)'. Whilst admitting the presence of cross-dressing boy dancers [*köçek*] in the taverns of Khiva, Mehmed Emin argued that 'without a shadow of doubt it came even to Khiva from Iran' (169).

In his own travelogue, Abdülhak Hamit would record his own distaste for the 'womanless society' of Iran (Enginün 1988, 16–17), whereas for the painter and archaeologist Osman Hamdi Bey it was the spread of the Shia practice of *mutʿah* or *Acem nikâhı* [temporary marriage] that represented a 'very contagious sickness' threatening the foundations of the Ottoman family, and foretelling the disappearance of Sunni Islam 'before a sect as pleasant as it is invasive' (Eldem 2010, 75–76). The language of sickness and disease reflects, in the age of cholera, the image of Iran within Ottoman political and sanitary discourse as an inexorable source of epidemic; this was perhaps exemplified most potently in the infamous illicit 'corpse trade' between Iran and the holy cities of Najaf and Karbala (Ateş 2010), but we may also read the *sui generis* prohibition on intermarriage between Ottoman and Iranian subjects, formalised in an 1874 *Nizamnâme*, as a kind of quarantine of Persian erotic 'sickness' (Kern 1999). The gendered customs, eroticism, and susceptibility to fantasy which threatened the imminent extinction of the Ottomans thus came to appear, gradually and then quite suddenly, to have a particularly Iranian origin and history: a theory to which the contemporary strength of the Turkmen and the ruination of Iran bore witness. As the traveller Süleyman Şükrü Karçınzade wrote of Iran in 1907, 'this nation, which gives no importance to anything other than poetry, can hardly hold their government accountable!' (2013 [1907], 129). The influence of these accounts can be seen quite prominently in the fiction of Ahmet Mithat Efendi. It is found, for example, in the dangerous, corrupting eroticism of the 'faultless male beauty' Acem Ali Bey in the 1882 novel *Dürdâne Hanım*, whose 'light,

[14]Here, I would argue, is one aspect where Persophilia differs from Orientalism, Ottoman or otherwise. As Edward Said argues, 'as a cultural apparatus Orientalism is all aggression, activity, judgment, will-to-truth, and knowledge'. The same is true, claims Ussama Makdisi, of its Ottoman form. But as Carter Findley has shown, the rise of Persophilia was marked by the 'virtual collapse' of Ottoman knowledge of Persian, except as discovered through self-analysis. See Said 1979, 204; Makdisi 2002; Findley 1989, 169.

striking Persian accent' tempts the underclasses of Istanbul into falling for their 'immoral' desires (Ahmet Mithat 1999 [1882], 16), and in the repressed, incestuous, and ultimately murderous eroticism of Sudâbe in his 1883 play *Fürs-i Kadimde Bir Facia, yahut Siyavûş* [*A Tragedy in Ancient Persia, or Siavash*] (Enginün 1990, 203–250).[15] Although in both cases Ahmet Mithat ultimately resolves the tension – in the first case by revealing Acem Ali Bey to be the alter-ego of Ulviye Hanım, a Turkish widow of Iranian or Indian ancestry and 'among the most beautiful of women' (Ahmet Mithat 1999, 59), and in the second case through Sudâbe's isolation and torture – in such works one can still see the outlines of Ömer Seyfettin's *çar-ebru* and Halide Edip's *pederşahilik* taking shape.

To be sure, the attribution of a dangerous, corrupting, and perverse eroticism to a cultural Other is hardly unique to the Ottoman case. A similar depiction of the Persianate corruption of the Abbasid period was promulgated by early twentieth-century Arab literary historians, such as Taha Hussein and Ahmad Amin (Massad 2007, 51–98), and earlier Iranian reformers like Mīrzā Aqā Khān Kermānī had written similar invective about the influence of the Arabs upon Persian (Zia-Ebrahimi 2016, 57–58). What made this issue existential for Ottoman literary reformers was that, in contrast to the emergent nationalist canon of Arabic and Persian texts, there appeared to be no example of Turkish high literature free from prior contamination. Whereas both Iranian and Ottoman intellectuals praised the supposedly 'pure' Persian of the *Shahnameh*, for example, there were no at-hand equivalents for Turkish: from the eleventh-century *Kutadgu Bilig* to the poetry of Ahmed Yesevî, Yunus Emre or Fuzulî, the corpus of Turkish literature appeared inextricable from its Persianate context, the still relatively meagre achievements of nineteenth-century Turkology notwithstanding (Köprülü 2006). Folk literature and the Turkish oral tradition would ultimately present similar issues. The search for what Ömer Seyfettin termed the 'stable ground' [*sağlam zemin*] of Turkish literature, a quilting point that could arrest the slide of Ottoman Turkish into a narcissistic, fantastical private language, was thus interminable, and became increasingly cannibalistic in orientation (1914). The initial agons of Ottoman Persophilia, as expressed in early texts like Ziya Paşa (1829–1880) 1868 essay 'Şiir ve İnşa' ['Poetry and Prose'], were figures of the Ottoman *divan* tradition like the prose writers Veysî (1561–1628) and Nergisî (c. 1580–1635) (1868). Although both were widely-read and prolific authors, their exclusion from the incipient Ottoman canon in texts like Recaizâde Mahmud Ekrem's 1885 *Kudemâdan Birkaç Şair [A Few Poets From Among the Greats]* or Abdülhalim Memdûh's 1888 *Tarih-i Edebiyât-ı Osmâniyye [History of Ottoman Literature]* increasingly marginalised the content of their works in favour of their value as rhetorical targets; indeed, as Persophilia consolidated as a discourse, Veysî and Nergisî would attain an increasingly demonic character, 'the two tyrant pens' who brought the language to its Persianate nadir (Yöntem 1911).

It did not take long, however, for the rhetorical targets of Persophilia to move onto those contemporary Ottoman writers accused of revisionism. Ziya Paşa was among its first victims. In his 1876 *Tahrib-i Harâbât* [*The Destruction of Ruins*], Namık Kemal fiercely criticised Ziya Paşa's 1875 poetry anthology *Harâbât* for 'reviving the Persian

[15]Ahmet Mithat's adaptation of this story from the *Shahnameh* does not sustain the same ambiguities as Ferdowsi's original: there is no doubt here that Sudabeh is wholly corrupt, and Siavash faultless. See, by contrast, Dabashi 2019, 91–92.

style' and abandoning the reformist movement (Bilgegil 1973; Namık Kemal 1885). Yet it was the poet Muallim Naci (1850–1893) – the author of *Heder*, and the figure whom Ömer Seyfettin deemed the last great defender of the Ottoman Persianate – who represented Persophilia's greatest betrayal. Naci's early writings were staunchly set against literary ornamentation, and his familiarity and fluency with the techniques of European literature made him appear as the exemplary young modernist (Tanpınar 1988, 595–596). Seeing a kindred spirit, in 1883 Ahmet Mithat Efendi invited him to edit the literary section of *Tercüman-ı Hakikat*, and he soon married into Ahmet Mithat's family. Already in their correspondence, however, there were worrying signs: when Naci approvingly quoted a passage from Hafez, for example, Ahmet Mithat responded in disgust that the Persians only describe nature through the lens of erotic fantasy, and can only see the beauty in a cypress tree by linking it to the body of a boy beloved (Ahmet Mithat and Muallim Naci 2011 [1893]: 36–37). Once at *Tercüman-ı Hakikat*, however, Muallim Naci suddenly began writing and publishing erotic poetry in the Persianate mode (Tanpınar 1988, 597–598). The reaction was swift: in 1885 Ahmet Mithat expelled Muallim Naci from the newspaper and banned his vocabulary from print, including the term *çar-ebru* (Tökgöz 1930, 39). In the following years Muallim Naci engaged in harsh polemics against reformist authors like Recaizade Mahmud Ekrem, and in turn became the target of their attacks (Seviner 2020): in Halit Ziya [Uşaklıgil]'s 1896 novel *Maî ve Siyah* [*The Blue and the Black*], for example, the poet protagonist Ahmet Cemil is menaced by a thinly-veiled caricature named 'Raci,' whose poetry is as dissolute and reactionary as his morals (1897). Yet perhaps what bothered these writers most was how, in his personal life, Naci in fact appeared to be 'impeccably moral:' there was something inexplicable in his inability to cede the expression of a mode of eroticism which he, himself, did not appear to uphold (Ahmet Rasim 2016, 129–130; Sarıtaş 2021, 131).

Heder [*The Waste*], which was written before Naci's death in 1893 but not published until after the 1908 Young Turk Revolution, can be read almost as an anticipation of, and retrospective answer to, *Maî ve Siyah* (Muallim Naci 2017 [1909]). The rather thin plot of the play largely serves to connect various literary discussions between the main characters; like Halit Ziya's novel, it opens at a gathering amongst Istanbul's literati. But in contrast to Ahmet Cemil's earnest search for a living, organic language 'completely like a human being,' the characters of *Heder* – above all Kâmil Bey, whose literary pronouncements take up much the text – revel in the nihilistic enjoyment of the dead and useless Persianate.[16] After reciting a couplet in Persian, he declares, 'Probably you didn't like that. Because it has become fashionable to dislike Persian. I like the right words, the beautiful words, no matter what they are. Let's not like the Arab, let's not like the Persian. Or shall we be a little devilish and enjoy ourselves the way we are?' (83) Throughout the play Kâmil Bey defends the eroticism of the fantastical *çar-ebru* not out of any real moral conviction but rather out of transgressive and self-destructive pleasure: it is what gives old poetry, he claims, its 'taste and flavour' (Muallim Naci 2017, 60). As he proclaims at a party towards the start of the play, 'one doesn't give up fulfilment … and *çar-ebru*-hood passes too. The one I love is still fresh and beautiful!' (57). Up to now we have had a movement of coding the Persianate as a negative juxtaposed against reality,

[16]For a reading which emphasizes instead a more melancholic (although still decadent) reading of *Heder*, see Dolcerocca 2021.

against reproductive futurity and the social order, and against both language and life itself: in *Heder*, it seems to me, we have a figure who has fully accepted and embraced that queer negativity and found within it a perverse and bountiful source of enjoyment.[17] And it is perhaps for this reason that *Heder*, despite its modern format, clear language, and general obscurity, appears so reviled, repulsive, and dangerous in Ömer Seyfettin's 'Yeni Lisan.'

Ömer Seyfettin could not, of course, countenance such nihilistic enjoyment except through its abjection; its very enunciation in *Heder* testified to the thorough contamination of Ottoman eroticism by the Persianate. Like many of the Turkish intellectuals of his generation, his thought in this regard was heavily influenced by the writings of Büchner, Spencer, Haeckel, and Le Bon; as M. Şükrü Hanioğlu has explored, during this time a positivist organicism became the unifying epistemological frame through which all phenomena – natural, social, psychological, intellectual – were understood (1995, 204–209). Ömer Seyfettin synthesised the biologism of these authors with his own particular interest in Sade. One may, of course, recount the endless variety of decapitations, disembowelments, cannibalism, and necrophilia in his writing: Tahir Alangu's biography of Ömer Seyfettin is likely one of the few to end with an explicit photograph of the subject's autopsy (1968, 547). But perhaps his most telling text in this regard is a little-read short story from 1909 entitled 'Busenin Şekl-i İptidaisi' ['The Primitive Form of the Kiss'], which depicts an encounter between a masochistic client and a prostitute who cannot bear to be kissed (Ömer Seyfettin 1909). The client arrives yearning for a past 'before history and before religion', in which men would 'tear each other apart' in order to reproduce. Upon their meeting, however, the prostitute declares that he is in fact a sadist, citing her reading of *Justine, or The Misfortunes of Virtue* (1791) (Sade 2012 [1791]). When he pleads ignorance, she explains that sadism is 'a terrible male disease' that, when contracted, causes him to 'pull out her hair, gouge out her eyes, pour acid onto her face, stab needles and skewers into her body, and cut off her nose or ears; sometimes he kills her. But how? In the most terrible and glorious ways …' (Seyfettin 1909, 12). Those familiar with Ömer Seyfettin's infamous 1914 war-story 'Beyaz Lâle' ['White Tulip'] may note that the list of tortures mirrors those enjoyed by the Bulgarian Major Radko (Berktay 2010, 110). Here, however, this sadism is connected to a primeval and animalistic eroticism: 'our forefathers who lived in ancient ages were terrible sadists. They were biting our mothers like those pheasants that kill their females with their beaks' (Seyfettin 1909, 12). The evolved eroticism of the kiss, Ömer Seyfettin writes, is a mere trace of the 'atavistic' pleasure of the bite; the story ends as the client resumes his ancestral sadistic role, kissing and biting the prostitute as she whispers for mercy 'but does not resist'. The identification of kissing with primeval biting was a prominent feature of both English and French-language writing on sadism during this period (Moore 2016, 32), and indeed almost the exact same metaphor is employed in Ömer Seyfettin's 1919 two-part story 'Horoz' ['Rooster'] and 'Dünyanın Nizâmı' ['The Order of the World']. In the first part of the story, a young girl witnesses a rooster pecking a hen to death and is disturbed to find that it reminds her of her father; in

[17]It may be clear that I am alluding to Edelman's formulation of the 'sinthomosexual' here. I would not argue that Kâmil Bey (or Muallim Naci) precisely fits this notion, but rather that within the sexual futurity of Ömer Seyfettin he occupies an analogous, if distinct, negative role. See Edelman 2004, 35.

revenge she kills the rooster with a stone. In the second part, she dreams of a great dragon who tells her that 'cruelty is a favour to hens, a blessing, a delicacy', and in turn bites, mutilates and kills her. She awakes in ecstasy, now content with 'the order of the world' and whispering of the 'sweet, beautiful, spiritual agony' she experienced and 'the distinct pleasure of pain, of being beaten, being oppressed, bitten, and torn to shreds' (Ömer Seyfettin 1919b; 1919c). In 'Harem' (1918), Ömer Seyfettin juxtaposes this sadomasochism against the sterile bourgeois Ottoman family: the story depicts the married couple of Sermet and Nazan, who have descended into petty bickering and mutual contempt due to their combination of formal, Europeanised manners with the practice of harem/selamlik gender segregation. It is only when the dominatrix-like Meliha suddenly arrives within the harem and, quite literally, whips Meliha into shape, that their marital love and libido is restored (1918).

Sadomasochism, for Ömer Seyfettin, thus serves to redeem Persianate gender segregation, and to find within it a new source of excessive enjoyment aligned instead with a vital and productive eroticism. Insofar as Ömer Seyfettin aligns Sadean pleasure to biological imperative, he differs greatly from his contemporaries who, although likewise rooting sadism in Haeckelian atavism, considered it a fundamentally destructive and degenerationist force (Moore 2016, 47–49). Similarly, after 'Busenin Şekl-i İptidaisi' Ömer Seyfettin remained relatively faithful to Sade, and distinct from most sexologists of the period, in generally refusing to essentialize sadism and masochism as fundamentally gendered positions. Most interesting among his subjects, then, are those men and women whose desire places them in the normatively 'opposite' category; masochists who, even temporarily, awaken their latent sadism, or innate sadists who are conditioned by their social gendering into embodying, albeit generally unsuccessfully, their expected masochistic position. It is in this light that stories such as 'Eleğimsağma' ['Rainbow'] (1917) in which a young girl supernaturally becomes a man for a day in order fulfil her active, extroverted erotic desires, have been appropriated by contemporary critics as an early representation of transmen in Turkish literature (Soydan 2020, 11). Although, as Alison Moore has argued, we should be wary of uncritically conflating sadistic desire with a fascistic politics, it seems to me that it is not really Ömer Seyfettin's sadism that is at issue but rather his vitalism, and his alignment of sadistic pleasure with the survival of the Turkish language, race, and state (Moore 2016, 162). Unlike Bataille, for instance, Ömer Seyfettin does not really propose that the sadomasochistic relation may lead towards a 'self-shattering,' a new mode of 'communication' (Bataille 1986 [1957]; Direk 2007, 111–113). If, as Žižek has argued following Lacan, Sade represents a 'form of the perverted realization' of Kantian universal ethics (Lacan 1989; Žižek 1998), then we can hardly speak more positively of Ömer Seyfettin's conflation of Sade with the racist particularism of Büchner, Spencer, Haeckel, and Le Bon. It is for this reason that Ömer Seyfettin's eroticism remains, for me, essentially fascistic in inclination, and why the attempt to read his work reparatively appears especially treacherous.

Perhaps surprisingly, Halide Edip's early writings share a great deal of conceptual commonality with Ömer Seyfettin's in this regard, albeit from a radically different perspective. In *Harap Mabetler* [*Ruined Temples*], a collection of prose poems and short stories mostly written before the 1908 Revolution, she depicts the oppression of women as at once horrific, universal, and as forming the fundamental basis of art, culture, and intellectual development: as she writes in 'Eller' ['Hands'], which she

composed when she was about fourteen or fifteen, 'the womanhood of each generation is forever drowned in tears and blood for the poetry, pleasure, philosophy and amusement of the next' (Adıvar 2020 26). Like Ömer Seyfettin, the early Halide Edip views women's 'dark destiny' as an 'eternal wretchedness', but one that is tragically constitutive of humanity's reproductive futurity: among the women's hands that narrator sees are the 'silken hands of the unborn children of tomorrow', pleading uselessly to be stillborn. A demonic black skeleton, 'stretching from the East to West', responds: 'Do you know that without the eternal misery of womanhood, there would be neither poetry nor pleasure?' In both perceiving and perpetuating this cataclysmic vision through her writing, the poetess thus becomes a figure of masochist enjoyment. And yet as Hazal Halavut notes, there is a gradual shift in the tone within *Harap Mabetler*; the immense pessimism of her early writings is tempered by an increasingly emancipatory depiction of Ottoman and Turkish history (2021). Already in 1896, the feminist author Fatma Aliye (1862–1936) had declared that the oppression of Turkish women was neither eternal nor rooted in divine law but had a specific historical origin: 'it was not long ago that Ottoman women fell into ignorance. It started with the Ottoman conquest of Persia. Among the Persians, women were despised and kept in a state of ignorance. Just as we absorbed Persian literature and their material things, so too did we take in their customs regarding women. It is due to this that our women have fallen into this state' (1896, 2).

Within Ottoman feminism, then, there was emergent Persophilic discourse which aimed to transform an existentialist problem into a contingent one of culture. The influence of Gökalp gave this discourse a coherent, if vague, sociological foundation. Gökalp located the origins of misogyny in ancient Iranian Zoroastrianism, which converted a nomadic and fluid dialectic of masculine asceticism and feminine shamanic magic into a rigid, civilised dualism between the male Magi, to whom both divine and temporal power was arrogated, and the female witch, who became taboo (Gökalp 2019, 160–161; Saraçgil 2005, 175). To be sure, Gökalp's notion had numerous antecedents, including the egalitarian primitive communism of Engels (2010), but a more proximate influence may have been Azeri intellectual Ahmet Ağaoğlu, who had in 1901 already argued that nomadic Turkic society had been characterised by an absolute gender equality until 'they were assimilated by the Iranians' (see Shissler 2002, 246). Curiously, Ağaoğlu had previously been a fervent exponent of Persian nationalism and had made precisely the reverse argument ten years earlier (1891), demonstrating (as in the case of script reform) the extent to which the contours of later Turkish nationalist discourse were shaped by Iranian and Azeri intellectuals. Ultimately, for Gökalp, 'Magian' Iran' became the source of a primordial tyranny whose traces continued to fester and surface within the Hellenistic, Roman, Arabic and Turkic civilisations; the Turks, as among the last races corrupted, were thus uniquely positioned to overcome it.[18] In connection with this thought, Halide Edip's feminism moved from a universalist project to a deeply particular one. And it is in this way that I, in part, explain what Halavut terms her 'withdrawal from witnessing' between 1909 and 1916 (2022): whereas the early Halide Edip could see in the existential oppression of women the

[18]An older notion of *zandaqah* ['heresy,' but in original usage likely 'Zoroastrianism' or 'Manicheanism'] was also redeployed by Arab literary historians during this period to refer to the effects of Iranian literary influence; Gökalp's particular formulation, however, seems distinct. See Massad 2007, 70.

grounds for a common solidarity across the Ottoman peoples, the post-*Yeni Turan* Halide Edip was committed instead to a specifically Turkish project of overcoming the Persianate negative. Such a project would continue well into the Republic: as the ideologue and historian (and Atatürk's adopted daughter) Afet İnan (1908–1985) wrote in *The Emancipation of Turkish Woman* (1962), within Zoroastrianism 'woman was a symbol of filth and evil and all wicked deities were represented as females', and thus the project of Kemalism had been to purge 'the patriarchal family system of the Persians' from Turkish social life (1962, 21). If Ömer Seyfettin's writings came to constitute 'the full demonology of Turkism', to use Halil Berktay's words, those of Halide Edip solidified the Persianate abject as the negative of Turkish feminism: a dynamic only reinforced after 1979 (2010, 75).

Conclusion: the serpent queen

In January 2021, the formerly autonomous rector of Boğaziçi University in Istanbul was replaced, by presidential decree, with an academician more politically aligned with the ruling Justice and Development Party [AKP]. The decision provoked a broad and enduring wave of resistance and protest from both students and faculty at the University, as well as within wider civil society (Hajjaji 2021). On January 22, a group of students organised an art exhibition at Boğaziçi in support of the protests, with one exhibit featuring a collage of the Masjid al-Haram in Mecca framed by four variant LGBTQ pride flags, with the central Kaaba replaced by an image of Şahmeran, a half-woman half-serpent figure originating from Kurdish, eastern Turkish, Armenian, and Iranian mythology. An attached artist's statement explained that the *şahmeran* motif, as a beloved union of two long despised and oppressed subjects, represented a 'secret mockery and rebellion against patriarchal power'; by placing her in the location of the Kaaba, the artist sought to criticise 'a fictitious religion which is the greatest motivator of social misogyny', and emphasise instead a utopian politics of women's emancipation, queer liberation, and animal rights (Kıpçak 2022). The official reaction was brutal and swift, forming part of an intensifying crackdown on LGBTQ rights and representation in Turkey mirroring (and largely ideologically rooted in) the contemporaneous conservative backlash against queer and trans people in the United States, the United Kingdom, and much of Europe. In an article published in the wake of the exhibition, the art historian Christiane Gruber noted how the composite figure of the pre-Islamic, Persianate *şahmeran* (as well as Burak, the human-faced steed of the Prophet) has been adopted to represent the intersectional struggle of women, Kurdish populations, transpeople and queer communities within contemporary Turkey (2021). Indeed, although the Şahmeran myth had previously been adapted by writers like Tomris Uyar and Hulki Aktunç, it is only in recent years that the use of the image has spread more widely: by Kurdish and queer visual artists, for instance, or appropriated as a Netflix serial (Aktunç 1976; McKernan 2020; Tamtekin 2022; Turagay and Başaran 2023; Uyar 2023 [1973]). 'The age-old figure of Şahmeran', Gruber concluded, 'has made a strong comeback in the Turkish public sphere, acting as a perilous testing ground, especially for members of the LGTBQ and Kurdish communities'.

It is tempting, to be sure, to thus end this article with the return of the Persianate repressed; a framing that has been used elsewhere to refer to the adoption of Persianate

vocabulary by contemporary queer communities in Turkey (Mansbridge 2017). Indeed, there is something striking about how precisely the *şahmeran* appears to reverse the terms of Gökalp's *pederşahilik*. And yet it must be remembered that both Gökalp's notion, and its usage by Halide Edip, were fundamentally intended to *institute* a regime of productive, patriotic heteronormativity: it was not that a prior queer Persianate was 'repressed', per se, but rather that its queerness is itself an effect of the discourse of 'radical break', the negative ground against which nationalist heteronormativity was projected. In linking together a critique of a 'fictitious' Islam alongside a positive programme of environmental justice and animal rights, it is rather evident that *şahmeran*, as depicted on the collage, was used here fundamentally as an instrumental and strategic locus of resistance against what Evren Savcı calls 'neoliberal Islam': that is, a neoliberalism that itself makes instrumental and strategic usage of Islamic imagery and rhetoric (2021, 7–11). The issue arises for me because of how, *within its own theorisation*, the Persianate has so often been framed as an emancipatory, cosmopolitan tendency juxtaposed against a repressive (Arab) Islam and the violent ruptures of contemporary nationalism. Although he rejects the term Persianate, for example, it is evident that the 'Balkans-to-Bengal complex' of Shahab Ahmad is not especially different from 'the Bengal to Bursa zone' of the historian Abbas Amanat; it represents an antediluvian cosmopolitan ethos, rooted in the poetics of Hafez and Rumi, and deliberately suppressed by the vandalism and enforced amnesia of colonialism, the postcolonial nation-state, and contemporary Islamic fundamentalism (Ahmad 2016, 32–46; Amanat 2018, 29).

Of course, there is the problem of falling into a familiar 'good Muslim, bad Muslim' rhetoric (Mamdani 2004). There is also the danger, as Judith Butler notes, of constructing the premodern Persianate as a 'site of lost pleasure' which promises 'the proleptic return of a prior and lost happiness' (1999, 16). But more crucially, for me, is that by positing 'the Persianate' as an ontological premodern (or pre-national, or pre-heteronormative), it is necessary to define what this Persianate actually consisted of vis-à-vis Arabic, Turkish or some other cultural sphere: and to do so, one must both accept as *fait accompli* and continuously *reenact* the very surgery upon the Ottoman literary interculture (for example) that Persianate Studies, in its historiographic narrative, has deemed the catastrophe of the nationalist epoch. This, for me, is the importance of Hamid Dabashi's intervention in *Persophilia: Persian Culture on the Global Scene* (2015), which explores how Persian literature adapted to, and was adapted by, the early modern European bourgeois public sphere, and how this literature was then reencountered and reappropriated by Persian writers and poets within a new transnational context. There are clear differences between the Persophilia Dabashi describes and what I have outlined in the Ottoman context: the former is an uncanniness, a 'foreign familiarity', whereas the latter is all abjection and estrangement: both, importantly, are on the side of the drive. But what is most crucial is that the 'Persianate', as currently constituted, appears thus as an *effect* of Persophilia rather than its precedent: the critical potential of studying Persophilia is not the discovery of an 'alternative modernity', but rather 'an alternative theory *to* modernity' (Dabashi 2015, 66, 231). As in the European case, this Persophilia is hardly by nature emancipatory or cosmopolitan. Indeed, with the establishment of the Republic, the generally positive attitudes of writers like Namık Kemal, Ömer Seyfettin, and Halide Edip towards Arabic literature

quickly soured into a base racism, as Ottoman Persophilia gradually realigned alongside a fundamentally anti-Semitic European form exemplified by Gobineau and Renan.[19]

But if I have focused here upon the way in which the writers of the National Literature period framed their projects of utopian linguistic, gendered, and sexual futurity, it is only because it is their writings and their ideology which contemporary Turkish nationalism claims as its precedent and origin: as we have seen, in detail, the sexual futures of Ömer Seyfettin and Halide Edip – a compulsory, atavistic sadomasochism, or a return to an ungendered, nomadic political sphere – were in fact remarkably different, and could today even be read as potentially subversive. Yet the canon of Turkish literature also has its own dead paths, with their own dead Persianates: I have not discussed here, for instance, the Persianate negatives of the Edebiyat-ı Cedide and the Fecr-i Âti schools, or of the Neo-Hellenic strand of Turkish literature, or indeed the Persianates of underclass subcultural genres like 'Iranian cabaret' [*Acem kantosu*]. Nor have I much discussed here the role that Iranians themselves, as expatriates or exiles, played in the formulation of Persophilia, and their own reencounters and reengagements with Persian in the late Ottoman and Turkish context. As I have proposed earlier, what sustains the Persianate as a medium of resistance and critique may be precisely the contradictory meanings that it holds; what may prove most interesting are the possibilities of exploring and taking on the negativity of 'that ornate language' which, as Ömer Seyfettin proclaimed in 1911, was 'fit only for the subjects of pleasure and desire' (Ömer Seyfettin 1911, 6).

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[19]As Zeynep Çelik has shown, the loose and heterogenous Ottoman and Turkish counter-discourse to Orientalism also made use of Persophilic rhetoric; for instance, in Namık Kemal's stringent critique of Renan. Ironically, the rapprochement between the Turkish Republic and Pahlavi Iran in the 1930s was founded upon an ideological anti-Arabism which directly borrowed from Renan's claims. See Namık Kemal 1910; Çelik 2020.

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